

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 1

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator describes a solo hike that turns into a fight for survival on an exposed mountain ridge.

1

The forecast had promised a clear afternoon, and so I had set off from the trailhead in nothing but a thin fleece, with a half-empty water bottle and the smug confidence of a hiker who had walked the same ridge a dozen times before. The sky above me was the colour of polished steel. A pale sun hung listlessly behind it, neither warming the air nor lighting it properly. I should have paid more attention.

2

By the time I reached the saddle between the two peaks, the wind had begun to whisper through the heather, which until that point had been still. A few minutes later, the whisper became a sigh, then a snarl. The temperature dropped so quickly that I thought, foolishly, that I had imagined it. I told myself that the cold front would pass in ten minutes. I told myself a great many things. None of them were true.

3

The first sleet came at me sideways, like grit thrown by a cruel hand. Within seconds the brittle yellow grass at my feet had been silvered, and my fleece, that gentle and useless garment, was already wet through to the skin. I crouched behind a low cairn and tried to think. Below me, the path I had come up had vanished into a heaving white. Above me, the way to the summit had been swallowed too. I was, very suddenly, nowhere at all.

4

A small voice at the back of my mind, sounding very much like my late father, asked me politely whether I had told anyone where I was going. The answer, of course, was no. I had not. I had a phone with one bar of signal that flickered in and out of existence, and a head torch with batteries that I had been “meaning to replace”. The voice did not say anything else. It did not need to.

5

I forced myself to move. Standing still in that wind was a slow, sociable form of suicide. I edged downhill, sideways, in the direction I judged the path to be, testing each tussock of grass before I trusted it with my weight. The mountain, which had felt so familiar that morning, had become a stranger — a moody, irritable stranger who muttered around my ears and tried, every few steps, to push me over. Twice I went down hard on my knees. The second time, my palm came up red. I looked at it for what felt like a long time before I understood that it was blood, and that I was the source of it.

6

After perhaps twenty minutes — though it could have been an hour, the storm had eaten time — the slope levelled off and the wind eased a fraction. I made out, through the white, a darker shape: a low stone bothy, half buried in the lee of a boulder. I had walked past it many times and never given it a second thought. Now I stumbled towards it the way a drowning man stumbles towards a raft. The door, when I shoved it, gave way at once. Inside there was a wooden bench, a stub of candle in a tin, and a single dry blanket folded with absurd neatness on a high shelf. Someone — some stranger, in some other storm — had thought of me before I had thought of myself.

7

I sat on the bench, shivering so violently that I bit my tongue and tasted iron. I wrapped the blanket around my shoulders. I did not light the candle, because I did not trust my hands not to drop it. After a long time, I noticed that I was no longer shaking quite so hard, and that my breathing had slowed. The wind outside still scoured the door, but in here, in this little island of stone, it could not reach me.

8

I have hiked that ridge many times since. I always tell someone where I am going. I always carry a waterproof, a spare layer, and a head torch with batteries that work. I am, in short, a tedious companion on a hill these days. I do not mind. I think often of the stranger who folded that blanket, and I think too of the woman I was before the storm — confident, hurried, lucky. She would not recognise the woman who, every time she sets out, pauses at the trailhead and looks, just once, at the sky.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator describes herself as having “the smug confidence of a hiker who had walked the same ridge a dozen times before.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about her attitude before the hike. [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that hint that the weather was about to turn bad. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says the wind “began to whisper... then a snarl.” Explain how this language makes the wind seem like a living creature. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator describes her fleece as “that gentle and useless garment.” What is **unusual** about this description, and what does it suggest about her view of her own preparation? [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator imagines a “small voice... sounding very much like my late father.”
(a) Why do you think the writer chooses to make the voice resemble her father? [1]

(b) The voice “did not need to” say anything else. What does this suggest about the narrator’s state of mind at this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator says that the mountain “had become a stranger — a moody, irritable stranger who muttered around my ears and tried, every few steps, to push me over.” Explain how the language used in this paragraph makes the mountain feel hostile. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. The narrator writes that “the storm had eaten time.” Explain what this phrase suggests about her experience of the storm. [2]

8. The blanket inside the bothy is described as “folded with absurd neatness on a high shelf.” What does the word **absurd** suggest about the narrator’s feelings at this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that shows the narrator was still in physical shock when she reached the bothy. [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator says she is now “a tedious companion on a hill these days.” What does this tell us about how she has changed since the storm? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the decline of independent bookshops in the digital age.

1

A generation ago, a high street without at least one independent bookshop was unthinkable. The shop's window, dressed each week by hand, was a small civic ritual: a careful conversation between the bookseller and the neighbourhood about what one ought, just then, to be reading. Today, that conversation has gone quieter. In Britain alone, the number of independent bookshops has fallen by more than a third since the year 2000; in Singapore, the closure of beloved names — Borders, Page One, Books Kinokuniya's smaller branches — has been mourned with a tenderness usually reserved for old cinemas.

2

The reasons are, on the face of it, unsurprising. Online retailers can stock more titles than any physical shop, deliver them in less than a day, and price them — through a combination of bulk purchasing and slim margins — well below what a small bookseller can afford to charge. Add to this the rise of the e-book, which weighs nothing and costs almost nothing to “stock”, and the economics seem to point in one direction. Yet the story is not so neat. The Bookseller, an industry magazine, reported in 2023 that membership of the Booksellers Association had in fact ticked up for the seventh year in succession. Something curious is happening: independent bookshops are dying **and** opening, often on the same street, often in the same year.

3

To understand the paradox, one must understand what a good bookshop is actually selling. It is not, in the strict sense, books. Books, considered purely as objects, are a commodity, and a commodity is exactly the sort of thing online retailers sell best. What an independent bookshop offers is something more elusive: curation, atmosphere, and a kind of slow, accidental learning that algorithms cannot quite reproduce. The recommendation that changes a teenager's reading life is rarely the one suggested by a “Customers who bought this also bought” panel. It is more often the one whispered, with a wry half-smile, by a bookseller who has watched the teenager hover, week after week, around the same shelf.

4

This is not nostalgia. Several studies in the last decade have begun to put numbers on what booksellers have long claimed instinctively. A 2019 report from the American Booksellers Association found that customers of independent bookshops bought, on average, 20 per cent more titles per year than buyers who used only online retailers, and read across a noticeably wider range of genres. Researchers at the University of York, studying browsing behaviour, found that physical browsing tends to expose readers to about four times as many “unintended” books — books they had not searched for — as online browsing. The mechanism, the researchers suggested, is simple: a shelf forces the eye to wander, while a search bar does not.

5

There is also the question of place. A bookshop is a peculiarly democratic kind of public space. Unlike a cafe, it requires no purchase. Unlike a library, it carries new titles and current debates. Unlike a museum, it does not insist on a hush. A child in school uniform, a retired teacher with a paper bag of vegetables, a tourist looking for shelter from the rain — all of them, in a good bookshop, are tolerated equally, and all of them, occasionally, leave with something they had not known they wanted. Town planners have begun, belatedly, to notice. A 2022 survey of “high-street health” in the United Kingdom identified the presence of an independent bookshop as one of the strongest predictors that a town centre was thriving, ahead of even cafes and grocers.

6

None of this is to deny the difficulty of the business. Margins remain punishingly thin. Rents, especially in city centres, continue to rise. Many of the small bookshops that have opened in the last five years rely, frankly, on a partner's income, a landlord's goodwill, or a founder willing to draw a salary that no reasonable accountant would recommend. Some have diversified, adding cafes, hosting paid events, or selling stationery and gifts alongside books — a move that older booksellers occasionally resent, but that younger ones treat as common sense. Others have adopted online ordering systems of their own, often through co-operatives such as Bookshop.org, which routes a share of every sale back to a participating independent shop chosen by the customer.

7

What seems to be emerging, then, is not a return to the old high-street model — that ship has, plainly, sailed — but a new and rather hardier creature: the independent bookshop as cultural venue. It is a place that sells books, yes, but also Friday-evening readings, school holiday workshops, signing queues that stretch around the block, and a kind of trusted, in-person recommendation that the internet, for all its volume, has yet to imitate. Whether this creature will multiply or remain a rare and protected species depends, in the end, on us: on whether the people who say they love bookshops also walk into them, and walk out of them, with a book they have paid for.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says the shop's window display was "a small civic ritual." Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the role of an independent bookshop in its neighbourhood. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** reasons why online retailers have an economic advantage over small bookshops. [2]

14. The writer ends Paragraph 2 by saying that "something curious is happening." What is the curious situation he is referring to? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Why does the writer say that books, "considered purely as objects, are a commodity"? Explain what this tells us about why bookshops cannot compete with online retailers on price alone. [2]

16. What is the effect of the writer's use of the phrase "whispered, with a wry half-smile"? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says, "This is not nostalgia." Why does he begin Paragraph 4 with this short sentence? [2]

18. The researchers at the University of York found that "a shelf forces the eye to wander, while a search bar does not." Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer claims a bookshop is “a peculiarly democratic kind of public space.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 5 that support this claim. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says that some new bookshops survive on “a founder willing to draw a salary that no reasonable accountant would recommend.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer describes the new bookshop as “a new and rather hardier creature.” Explain what is **effective** about describing a type of shop as a “creature.” [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **what makes a good independent bookshop different from an online retailer**, and **what challenges independent bookshops still face**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Unlike an online retailer, a good independent bookshop offers ...

— END OF PAPER —